

just over the trees they have no time to cock their guns and fire."

Suddenly the jungle thins out and a small clearing appears. Four armed soldiers guard its periphery as the helicopter swoops down and deposits us on wet ground. Even the landing spots are decided in an impromptu manner and changed everyday to avoid detection and fire by the LTTE. I am driven to meet Major General Jagath Dias, commander of the 57 Division, the main strike force of the army that has over 10,000 men with their armaments moving determinedly towards Kilinochchi. The divisional headquarters is a makeshift row of zinc sheet-covered huts. Dias uses one of these as his office. It bristles with communication equipment and has a large map that is updated by the hour to show the progress of his four brigades. Sporting a bushy moustache, Dias is hands on as is his boss Lt-General Sarath Fonseka who despite being away in the US on a well-earned holiday, calls everyday to check the progress.

Dias has fought the LTTE in previous years in many terrains. He refuses to be rushed into an all-out assault to capture the town or occupy highways as in the past. Instead, he uses guerilla tactics that the LTTE had specialised in. So his men move out in platoons into the jungles, clearing the area of mines. On the table is a large cross-sectional map with tiny blue flags to indicate where his platoons are engaging the LTTE. At any given time, they are fighting at 30 different points, forcing the LTTE to spread out its defences. Dias says, "We are deliberately drawing LTTE troops into the jungles as we find that they don't seem to fight there as well as before.

Now we are fighting a guerrilla war while the LTTE tends to rely on conventional tactics."

I travel to the frontline by a Tata truck that has an armour-plate chasis to protect against mines. We whizz past abandoned villages. My escort Colonel Priyantha Gunaratne points to LTTE bunkers and fortified *bunds* that the army had to destroy to overcome resistance. He claims that the civilians were forced to leave their houses by the LTTE who used them as a human shield when they retreated and also to recruit their young. They left their dogs behind and these have become a menace for the troops, poaching on their food and attacking some of them.

We reach Mallawi town, once a district centre, which now has most of its rooftops blown away.

In 2002, I had attended a press conference here held by LTTE chief Velupillai Prabhakaran after the then government had declared a ceasefire. He was in full command, having won in the previous years decisive military battles against a demoralised Sri Lankan Army that saw him gain control of districts in the North, East and parts of the West.

After 9/11, terror was a bad word and Prabhakaran cleverly sheathed his claws. For him, the ceasefire was an opportunity not only to set up LTTE's civil control over the region but also consolidate its armed wing. He formed a Tamil Eelam civil service cadre and police that even collected taxes and controlled law and order. His dream of establishing an independent Tamil nation seemed real till Mahinda Rajapakse emerged as the President in late 2005 and months later scrapped the ceasefire agreement and launched an all-out war.

Mallawi was also a centre for NGOs who pro-

IN SIGHT:
The army moves in to wrest control of areas in Mullaitivu province

SRI LANKAN ARMY



vided humanitarian aid to the Tamils living in the area. They were asked to leave in September when the offensive began. The Brigade Major Kaushal Gunashekara, who rides a Bajaj Pulsar with a gun-toting assistant seated behind, charges that many of them supplied arms and money to the Tigers. He takes me to a graveyard for the so-called LTTE martyrs where the stones are well-cemented, in contrast to the mud huts the residents lived in.

We reach the last checkpoint where a platoon is getting ready to head to battle, donning their backpacks and helmets. In their early 20s, they look

The Sri Lankan Army is using guerrilla tactics which was the LTTE's forte and is focussed on clearing them out of the Wanni jungles.